

Figure 3.3 Order of execution of Razor files: ViewStart, followed by the content page, then the layout page

ViewStart is executed before any pages it affects, making it the ideal way to set the layout for all those pages. If you take a look at the contents of the existing ViewStart file, you will see that is exactly what it does:

```
@{
    Layout = “_Layout”;
}
```

I mentioned that the ViewStart code is executed before the code in the page, enabling you to alter the global setting on a page-by-page basis if you need to. Any layout assignment that takes place in an individual page will override the ViewStart. Equally, if you place additional ViewStart files lower down the Pages folder hierarchy, layout assignments in those will override any assignments in ViewStart files higher up the hierarchy.

One final note about layouts: it is possible to nest layout files, so one layout references another. To achieve this, you need to explicitly assign a layout in a child layout. Figure 3.4 shows the relationship between a page, a nested (child) layout, and the main layout. The Index content is injected into the nested layout wherever `RenderBody` is placed. The merged content is injected into the layout file.